CLASS 3 HANDOUT

Boundaries

Finding Peace Within

What are they?

- Symbolic "fences" that protect our value
  - Keep others from coming into our space
  - Keep us from going into another's space
- Contain our reality (thoughts, feelings, choices, limits, behaviors) - our sense of who we are

Two components

EXTERNAL

External boundaries keep our physical body separate

- Allows us to choose the distance we want between ourselves and others and whether or not we allow someone to touch us
- This also includes sexual boundaries for distance and touch

INTERNAL

Internal boundaries protect our reality (thoughts, feelings, choices, limits, behaviors)

- Take responsibility for our reality versus blaming others
- Releasing the responsibility of the reality of others
  - Refrain from negative control, projection, and manipulation

Myths about boundaries

- I am being selfish or disobedient (feelings of guilt or shame)
- I will hurt others or be hurt by others
- They are permanent

Boundary violations

- Resentment: always is a boundary issue

EXTERNAL

- Getting into a person's space or personal belongings (unwanted touch, going through personal drawers/closet, checking a phone or purse/wallet)
- Listening to a conversation without permission

INTERNAL

- Yelling, name calling, ridiculing
- Shaming or patronizing (devaluing of any form)
- Negative Control: telling someone how they should feel, think, or act

Boundaries are personal

Each person's boundaries will look different from others

- What hurts? (how do you stop the pain?)
- What feels good? (pursuing joy)
- What is mine? (knowing your reality)
- What am I willing to lose or give up?

Barriers to boundaries

- Our Belief System (history and distorted thinking)
- Enabling: destructive form of helping
  - We attach ourselves to another's need for us
  - This builds resentment and we feel used or sorry for ourselves
- Enmeshed: overly involved in another
  - Excessively worry about another's problems
  - Become dependent on those around us which causes us to detach from ourselves

When we don't have boundaries

- We have defense mechanisms
  - Avoidance
  - Procrastination
  - Self-sabotage
  - Drama

Setting boundaries

- Realization of our own person apart from others (knowing our reality)
- Separation of identity: allows for "I" "me" and "self"
  - Gain self-awareness
  - Define your reality
- Saying "no"
  - Set limits
  - Practice self-control
  - Create goals and pursue with continued patience
- Putting boundaries into words
  - I would like to revisit this later when the energy has dissipated
  - I hear that you think I am [insert negative stuff]. I would like to think about this because I'm not sure what to do with it

Boundaries and relationships

- We are **RESPONSIBLE** for knowing the impact of our thoughts, feelings, and behaviors on another
  - Be sensitive but do not control
- When impacted or pressured by others, it is our responsibility to manage our reactions
  - Let go of the expectation
  - Communicate
- We **DECIDE** to adjust or relinquish something
  - We do not mindlessly lose our reality to another
- Openness (being vulnerable) and having boundaries leads to connection and intimacy

Boundary Sketches

HEALTHY BOUNDARIES

Healthy boundaries are like a house with a door with a doorknob on the inside only seperating us from others

- We choose when to open the door and let someone in
  - Allows for connection
- We choose when to leave the door closed
  - Protects us from others
  - Protects others from us

NO BOUNDARIES

No boundaries are like having nothing seperating us from others

- We do not know when we are being abused or abusing others
- Difficult to say "no"
- Can be easily taken advantage of

PARTIAL BOUNDARIES

Partial boundaries are like having gaps in your "wall" that seperates us from others

- At certain times and/or with certain people can set limits and protect oneself
- At other times and/or with other people may abuse or be abused

WALLS

Wall are like having a brick wall with no door isolating us from others

- Give solid protection but do not allow for connection at any level causing more isolation
- People may move from one kind of wall to another
- Anger - message of an erupting volcano
- Fear - retreat from others to keep safe
- Silence - emotions are turned off; "the silent treatment"
- Words - talks over people; oblivious to contribution of others

References

- **Facing Codependence** by Pia Mellody*
- **Changes that Heal** by Dr. Henry Cloud*
- **Boundaries** by Dr. Henry Cloud and Dr. John Townsend*
- **Beyond Codependency** by Melody Beattie*
- **Maybe You Should Talk to Someone** by Lori Gottlieb*

Exercise: Where are my boundaries?

*From **Forgiving Our Parents, Forgiving Ourselves** by Drs. David Stoop and James Masteller*

	Yes	No
Do I regularly say "yes" to others, especially family, when I really want to say "no"?		
Do I become burdened with other people's problems because they see me as the one to come to, and then feel resentful later?		
Do I find myself wanting what "we" want, or asking "What do we think?" instead of "What do I think?"		
Do I feel what other people feel, as if their feelings were mine, and can't stay objective?		

Answering "yes" may point to blurred boundaries that need clarifying.

The kind of boundary I use most (healthy, none, partial, or walls):

With family	
At work	
With friends	
With a partner	

Take-home: My boundary statements

*From **Breaking Free** by Pia Mellody and Andrea Wells Miller*

External boundary (my body)

- Physical: I have a right to control distance and touch with you, and you have a right to control distance and touch with me.
- Sexual: I have a right to control if, when, where, and how I am sexual with another person, and you have the same right.

Internal boundary (thoughts, feelings, behavior)

- I am responsible for what I think, what I feel, and what I choose to do or not do. You are responsible for what you think, feel, and do or don't do.
- If I am in a relationship with you, I am responsible for noting the impact of my thoughts, feelings, and behavior on you. I then can decide if I will adjust to make our relationship more comfortable. (This does not hold in a victim–offender situation: if I am authentically offended, my reaction is about your abuse, not about me and my history.)

1. The statement I will practice this week:

2. When, and with whom:

3. What I noticed when I said it, or thought it:

Group Questions

Check-in first Did you get to use True, Not True, or Questionable this week? What happened?

Answer from whichever level fits where you are tonight. It's fine to stay in Start.

Start

JUST STARTING OUT

1. In your own words, what is a boundary?

2. Think of a time someone respected your "no." How did that feel?

Go deeper

APPLY TONIGHT'S IDEAS

3. "Resentment is always a boundary issue." Think of a recent resentment: what boundary might have been missing?

4. Which kind of boundary do you use most with family, at work, and with friends: healthy, none, partial, or a wall? What tells you that?

Stretch

FOR A BIGGER CHALLENGE

5. What makes it hardest for you to say no, and what do you believe will happen if you do?

6. Where might you be crossing someone else's boundary (giving advice, checking up, telling them how they should feel)? What would stepping back look like?